



Cloud AI Adoption Roadmap for Higher Education Leaders

A strategy and planning guide
aligned with Microsoft's
Cloud Adoption Framework



Introduction

Higher education is at a turning point. In a rapidly evolving digital landscape, institutions are being asked to deliver more personalized learning, accelerate discovery, advance research, and operate with greater agility—often with fewer resources. In this environment, artificial intelligence and cloud technologies are emerging as critical tools for transformation.

According to IDC's 2024 AI opportunity study¹, 86% of education organizations are now using generative AI to empower students, faculty, and staff - nearly doubling from the year before. And for every dollar invested in generative AI, institutions are seeing an average return of \$3.2x within just over a year. This financial impact underscores the role of AI in advancing institutional business models, in addition to teaching, learning, and innovation.

AI is no longer an emerging trend but a fundamental enabler of new possibilities in higher education. Cloud capabilities enable greater innovation, security, resilience, and cost-effective infrastructure to support AI-powered advancements. Together, **AI and cloud computing are reshaping education—driving innovation while keeping the human at the center of learning.**

This playbook provides a practical approach to adopting AI in a way that aligns with institutional goals. It draws on Microsoft's Cloud Adoption Framework to guide education leaders through strategy development, responsible implementation, and long-term value creation.

We recognize the challenges that come with adoption—whether it's upskilling staff, addressing data security, or establishing responsible AI governance. Our goal is to help institutions accelerate their AI outcomes through informed, strategic conversations that put trust, responsibility, and the human experience at the center. We hope this playbook serves as a valuable resource as you continue leading your institution forward.



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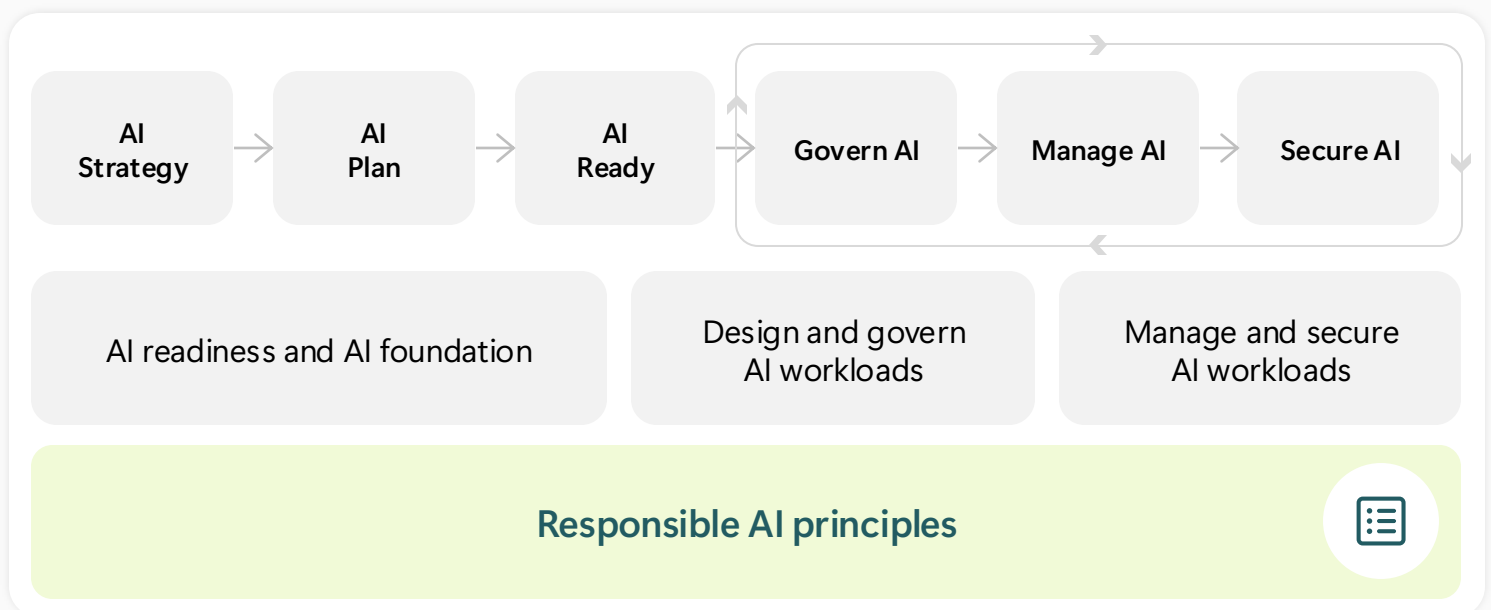
Who this eBook is for

This eBook provides guidance for developing an AI strategy aligned with institutional goals, and turning that strategy into an actionable adoption plan. It offers best practices for assessing readiness, defining governance, and designing solutions that support student success, faculty innovation, and operational excellence.

Successfully adopting AI at the institutional level requires more than new technology—it demands strategic leadership, cross-departmental coordination, and a clear plan for responsible implementation. Without this foundation, AI initiatives risk falling short of their potential to drive meaningful change. But by structuring and adopting an AI strategy grounded in cloud adoption best practices, universities can leverage AI to lead digital transformation in enhancing student success, driving faculty innovation, and optimizing operations.

The role of Microsoft's Cloud Adoption Framework (CAF) in AI adoption

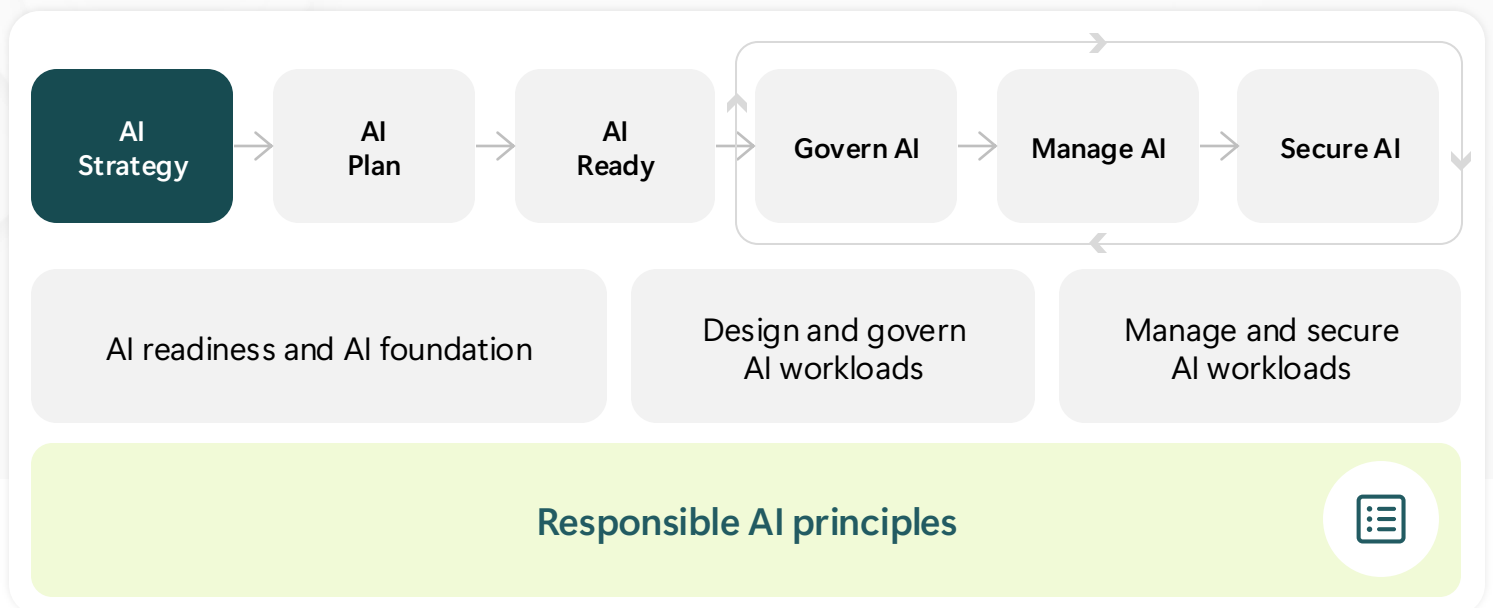
The Microsoft Cloud Adoption Framework (CAF) is a roadmap for universities to adopt and manage AI responsibly across every stage, ensuring AI adoption remains transparent and aligned with institutional values. Through the CAF, universities can confidently design, deploy, and govern AI while maintaining security, compliance, and maximizing institutional impact.



Developing an AI strategy

Adopting AI and cloud without a clear strategy can lead to resource and time inefficiencies, as well as governance and compliance risks. A well-defined AI strategy helps universities align AI with institutional goals, enabling smarter investments that enhance student experiences, streamline operations, and support research. It also strengthens collaboration across departments—bringing together IT, faculty, finance, and leadership under a shared governance framework to ensure responsible, coordinated AI deployment.

This first section covers the essential components of an AI strategy, providing best practices for identifying, developing, and deploying AI solutions to maximize institutional benefits.



Align AI strategy with institutional goals

Identify
AI use casesDefine your
AI tech strategyDefine your
AI data strategyDefine a responsible
AI strategyCreating an
AI adoption plan

Align AI strategy with institutional goals

Build leadership for AI adoption

A cross-functional leadership approach is key for aligning AI expertise, resources, and governance.

To do this, universities can create an [AI Center of Excellence](#) (AI CoE) made up of on campus leaders and experts. The primary role of the AI CoE is to provide structure and oversight to AI initiatives, and make sure they are aligned with institution goals and drive measurable impact. The AI CoE also establishes development standards, oversees compliance and ethical concerns, and fosters a culture of responsible AI across the organization.



AI CoE core functions

After defining roles and objectives, the CoE should begin operationalizing the following areas

	Role	Key Objective
Strategy	Align AI initiatives with institutional priorities and establish a scalable infrastructure for AI integration	Create a strategic plan for AI adoption and set guidelines for AI tools, data architecture, and scalable infrastructure
Business Integration	Identify opportunities to apply AI in teaching, research, and operations for improved outcomes	Surface practical, high-impact AI use cases across departments and align them with institutional goals
Adoption	Drive AI implementation through standardized processes and structured learning pathways	Ensure AI models support skill development, with established governance policies for responsible AI use
Data & Model Utilization	Leverage institutional and third-party data to support AI-driven decision-making	Promote effective data and model usage to generate insights and improve transparency, accuracy, and impact
Governance & Compliance	Oversee responsible AI, data privacy, and security compliance	Enforce structured policies and controls that promote responsible AI use across the institution

Align AI strategy with institutional goals

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Define your AI data strategy

Define a responsible AI strategy

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Identify AI use cases

Prioritize AI use for institutional impact

Universities should conduct an [internal assessment](#), document workflows, and engage stakeholders to identify inefficiencies and explore AI-driven solutions. Institutions can maximize impact by improving process efficiency, setting measurable goals, and leveraging organizational insights.



- Learn how higher education is reimagining student experiences with Azure OpenAI Service at the [Microsoft Education blog](#)
- Read more Microsoft [customer stories](#)

AI use case	Description	Customer story
24/7 personalized learning support	AI tutors deliver on-demand support, adaptive learning, and interactive practice to build confidence, deepen understanding, and accelerate mastery	Universitas Terbuka uses AI tutoring for 24/7 personalized support, boosting engagement and academic performance with instant curriculum-aligned responses
Adaptive instruction and content	AI adjusts content to learner needs to personalize instruction and boost engagement while providing real-time insights for course development and continuous improvement	Babson College utilizes AI-driven predictive models, personalized learning tools, and Microsoft Copilot to optimize lesson planning, tailor instruction, and enable adaptive, data-driven learning
Student engagement & campus support	AI assistants improve communication, streamline resource access, and enhance engagement, retention, and administrative efficiency	The University of South Florida enhances student engagement and campus support with AI by deploying chatbots, streamlining IT assistance, and improving access to essential resources
Secure learning at scale	AI detects cybersecurity threats in real time, supports rapid threat mitigation, and protects institutional data to strengthen security	Oregon State University utilizes Security Copilot in conjunction with Microsoft Sentinel and Defender to elevate OSU's proactive security measures to assess and respond to cyberthreats quickly
Accelerated research & academic discovery	AI can streamline administrative tasks, speeding publication and advancing research, analysis, and innovation	Georgia Tech leverages Azure OpenAI Service to drive EV innovation, uncovering insights for policy development and infrastructure advancement

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Define your AI technology strategy

Optimize AI investments for flexibility and control

An AI technology strategy ensures the right tools and platforms are chosen for generative and nongenerative AI needs. Institutions can customize with Microsoft's flexible AI solutions, which offer varying levels of control and flexibility. Investing in AI as a portfolio helps institutions measure ROI and scale sustainably, ensuring long-term success and adaptability.



- Read more about build or buy scenarios for your AI transformation at the [Microsoft Cloud blog](#)
- Take the [Azure AI readiness assessment](#) to assess your organization's AI capabilities and optimize your AI strategy



Copilot offerings

[SaaS](#) solution that boosts productivity with little to no technical expertise needed

- **Boost productivity** across Microsoft 365 apps with AI-powered assistance in writing, analyzing, and collaborating
- **Enhance workflows** in products like Azure, GitHub, and Power Platform, or in roles like sales and finance
- **Streamline business functionality** by customizing Copilot with specific skills, logic, or task-specific agents



Microsoft AI platforms

Flexible [PaaS](#) tailored to your AI goals, skills, and data—built for all levels of technical expertise

- **Build and deploy AI agents or apps** using no-code tools or custom development with Azure AI and Azure OpenAI
- **Access powerful prebuilt AI models** for language, vision, speech, and decision-making—no data science skills needed
- **Train and manage your own machine learning models** with your data and tools for greater control and customization



Azure AI infrastructure services

Azure [IaaS](#) for full control to train and deploy custom AI models

- **Use prebuilt AI models** for language, vision, and speech without needing deep ML expertise
- **Train custom models** on your own research data with full control
- **Run large-scale AI workloads** using Azure tools like CycleCloud, Batch, or Kubernetes

Hybrid approach

Use a combination of solutions to find the right tradeoff between out-of-the box value and level of technical customization that makes sense for your institution's AI transformation

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Deploy AI quickly with Copilot

Minimal technical expertise needed

Universities can adopt AI solutions with minimal setup, from free offerings like Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat to embedded Copilot capabilities in productivity, security, and operations tools

Extend and customize easily

Leverage Copilot Studio's graphical development environment for building AI powered assistants tailored to your institution's needs.

Additionally, institutions can [integrate external data sources and services](#) into Copilot using Microsoft Graph connectors and API plugins to enhance capabilities within workflows.



Copilot Chat

Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat provides AI assistance for everyday tasks



Microsoft 365 Copilot

Enhances productivity for faculty and administrators by providing a secure way to interact with enterprise-level institutional data in Microsoft Graph



In-product Copilot

Enhance institutional efficiency by driving productivity and improving data-driven decision making in applications used for academics and operational activities (such as Power Platform, Azure, Fabric, and Dynamics 365)



Role-based Copilot

Specialized AI solutions for specific business roles - such as Microsoft 365 for security, finance, sales, and service operations



Copilot Studio

Build, test, and deploy agents in a SaaS authoring environment for specific university needs

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Develop scalable AI solutions with AI platforms

Choose your level of control for your needs

Universities can tailor AI adoption with PaaS solutions, opting for fully managed services that simplify deployment or AI infrastructure that offers deep control for cutting-edge research

Deploy AI at scale without managing infrastructure

Institutions can use Microsoft's AI solutions to develop custom applications for research and student engagement, accelerate discovery and foster innovation —without the complexity of managing infrastructure



Take the [AI Readiness Assessment](#) to evaluate organizational preparedness for AI implementation across three key areas: data foundations, model management, and Azure Open AI

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)

Enhance tutoring, research, and study with a [RAG-based AI agent built with Azure AI Foundry](#) that leverages up-to-date sources to synthesize topics and deliver accurate explanations

Build with:

Azure AI Foundry / Azure AI Search

Fine-tune generative AI models

[Customize AI models](#) to personalize learning and streamline workflows with governance, APIs, and Azure AI Content Safety for privacy, security, and responsible use

Build with:

Azure AI Foundry / Azure AI Content Safety

Train machine learning models

[Use prebuilt AI models](#) to analyze student performance, enable adaptive learning, and improve decision-making

Build with:

Azure Machine Learning /
Data Science in Microsoft Fabric

Leverage non-generative AI models

Improve learning accessibility, engagement, and efficiency with customizable AI models and APIs for [natural language processing, search, monitoring, translation, speech, vision, and decision-making](#)

Build with:

Azure AI Foundry / Azure AI Services

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Access AI infrastructure to support compute-intensive academic research

Harness AI infrastructure to solve academic research challenges

Research workloads running on AI infrastructure enable researchers to process massive datasets with on-demand scaling and cost-effective cloud resources, eliminating infrastructure burdens. Azure CycleCloud, Azure Batch, and Azure Kubernetes Services enhance productivity with streamlined workflows and seamless integration, allowing researchers to focus on innovation.

Trusted cloud platforms power compute-intensive workloads, delivering reliable AI-driven insights, deep learning, and large-scale simulations. By harnessing AI, institutions can accelerate discovery, enhance collaboration, and drive new research breakthroughs.

Key use cases + customer stories

Optimize AI computing costs while ensuring research reproducibility

[University of Nottingham](#)

Enable AI model training and workload orchestration for advanced simulations and research

[University of Bath](#)

Support data analytics, AI-driven insights, and research collaboration across institutions

[North Carolina State University: Plant Sciences Initiative](#)

Conduct secure and efficient research while ensuring compliance with regulatory standards

[Oregon State University](#)

Create your AI tech strategy with flexible solutions

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Navigating pro-code and low-code AI development

Higher education leaders can balance customization, speed, and resources when selecting an AI development approach.

- **Low-code** provides a faster, more accessible path to AI adoption, integrating seamlessly with Microsoft 365 tools such as Teams for streamlined workflows
- **Pro-code** offers full control for building highly customized AI applications, integrating deeply with existing systems, and ensuring robust security

Institutions must weigh ease of use vs. flexibility to determine the right fit for their strategy. Rather than a one-size-fits-all approach, each solution fits within a spectrum of options, allowing institutions to combine tools in ways that best support their needs.

Guidance for building custom agents

Approach	Low-code	Pro-code
Out-of-box value	Delivers ready-to-use AI tools with native Microsoft 365 integration and fast implementation	Offers granular control over data, models, and infrastructure with tools for AI evaluation and compliance
Customization	Supports workflow enhancements with prebuilt connectors and natural language orchestration	Enables deep customization with full code access, agent orchestration, and choice of model
Trade-off summary	Enables quick deployment with prebuilt AI tools but with limited customization options	Provides full control and flexibility over AI models and infrastructure, but requires greater technical expertise
Customer Story	Milpark Education	University of Oslo

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AI Innovation starts with data, but many challenges hinder higher education AI adoption:

- **Low visibility & fragmentation:** Siloed data hinders access, analysis, and AI-driven real-time insights
- **Lack of agility & real-time access:** Aging systems delay AI-driven insights and limits student success, academic planning, and research
- **Security & compliance risks:** Sensitive data must remain protected from cyber threats while meeting strict compliance standards like GDPR and FERPA
- **AI readiness & data quality Issues:** Inconsistent and unreliable data weakens AI effectiveness, often leading to flawed insights



Check out the [blog post](#) to unleash your data and accelerate your transformation

A unified, intelligent data strategy maximizes the value of your education data

Universities need a structured data strategy that ensures accessibility, security, governance, and scalability to support learning, research, and operations

Data strategy component	Outcome
Modern Databases	Built for generative AI to deliver the scale, speed, and reliability needed for real-time analytics, intelligent experiences, and data-driven decisions
Insights & Analytics	Unified data and analytics for real-time, tailored intelligence - empowering leaders to make faster, smarter decisions
Compliance & Governance	A secure, compliant data platform leveraging Azure's Built-in security to protect data from every angle - enhancing visibility, safety, and compliance with end-to-end protection
AI	Intelligent data management empowers higher education leaders to drive innovation, streamline operations, and make informed decisions

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A responsible AI strategy in higher education requires clear governance to align with institutional values, uphold academic integrity, meet regulations, and promote trust, transparency, and ethical use in research and education.

Microsoft's Responsible AI approach is built on [six core principles](#):

- **Fairness** – AI systems should treat all people fairly
- **Reliability and safety** – AI systems should perform reliably and safely
- **Privacy and security** – AI systems should be secure and respect privacy
- **Inclusiveness** – AI systems should empower everyone and engage people
- **Transparency** – AI systems should be understandable
- **Accountability** – People should be accountable for AI systems

Implementing responsible AI principles necessitates a strategic approach across both academic and administrative functions. By using tools like [Azure AI Content Safety](#), institutions can build trustworthy, reliable AI systems that support their goals, uphold academic integrity, and promote student success.

Establish AI accountability & governance

Institutions should **designate an AI governance lead** or [AI Center of Excellence](#) (CoE) to oversee responsible AI adoption across academic programs, research initiatives, and administration

Align with responsible AI principles

Institutions should **adopt frameworks similar to** [NIST AI Risk Management Framework](#) (AI RMF) to strengthen fairness, transparency, and security in AI-driven academic assessments, faculty research, and administrative decision-making

Identify responsible AI tools

Universities should **implement responsible AI tools** to enhance explainability and conduct ongoing audits to align with compliance requirements

Understand legal and regulatory compliance

Higher education institutions **must monitor evolving AI regulations**, including [GDPR](#), [FERPA](#), and regional education policies, to ensure compliance, mitigate risks, and maintain institutional trust in AI-driven academic processes and student services

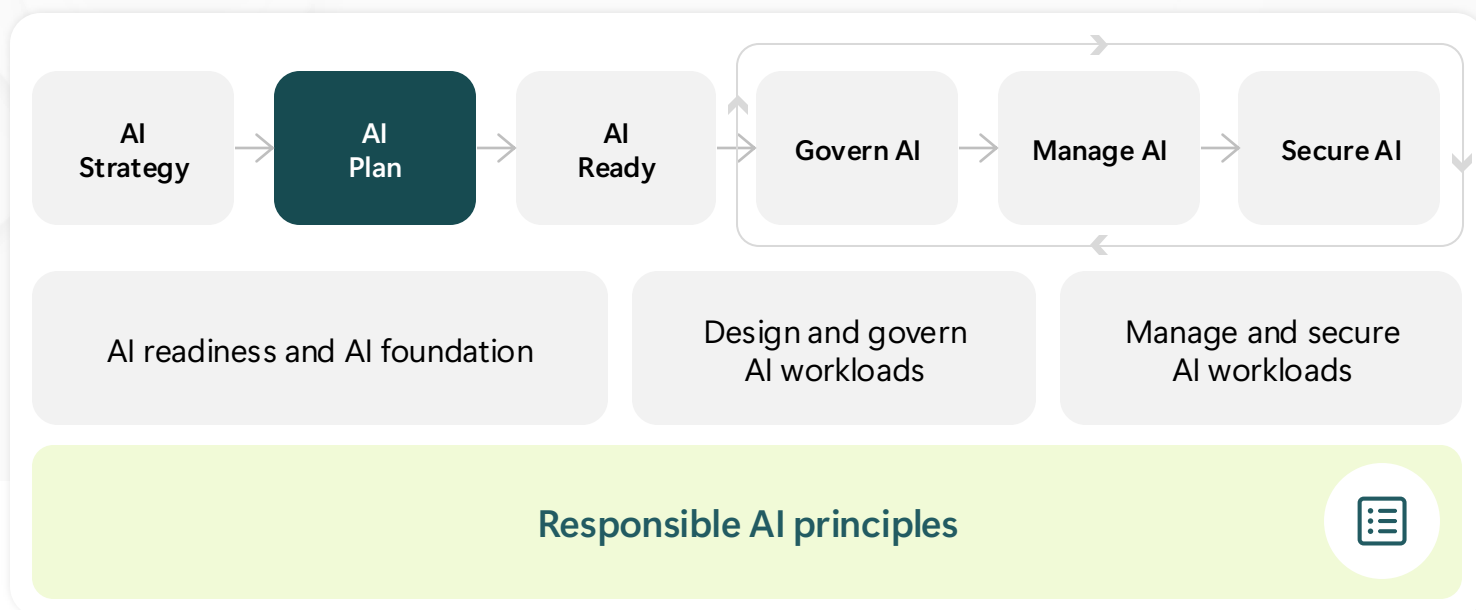


- Learn more about empowering [responsible AI practices](#)
- Complete the [learning path](#) to gain understanding of responsible use of AI in education
- Read about how to meet compliance standards such as [GDPR](#) and [FERPA](#)

Creating an AI adoption plan

A well-defined AI strategy sets the vision for transformation, but without a structured adoption plan, even the most ambitious initiatives risk falling short. An AI adoption plan bridges the gap between strategy and execution, ensuring AI efforts move beyond conceptual goals to deliver real business impact. By establishing a clear roadmap for implementation—including resource allocation, skill development, and technology deployment—organizations can translate strategic intent into practical outcomes that align with business objectives.

This next section covers the essential steps for turning AI strategy into action. From identifying the right infrastructure to scaling adoption across the organization, a structured approach ensures AI delivers measurable value and long-term success.



Assess AI skills to structure an AI adoption plan

Identify skilling needs to ensure AI readiness

A strategic approach is key to AI adoption in higher education. Assessing your institution's AI maturity ensures alignment with IT infrastructure, data governance, and institutional capabilities for effective implementation.

An AI maturity assessment helps decision-makers:

- **Evaluate** existing skills and identify gaps
- **Align** AI initiatives with institutional readiness
- **Maximize** impact and ensure long-term success

See the following table to assess your institution's AI maturity and readiness for adoption.



- Use the [Digital Skills Compass](#) as a personalized guide to upleveling your technology skills
- Leverage the [Microsoft Learn for Organization Playbook](#) for skilling up your entire team for AI

Assess your AI maturity level to determine readiness

Maturity Level	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 4
Skills required	Foundational: Basic AI literacy, ability to integrate data sources, create simple prompts	Emerging: Hands-on experience with model selection, data cleaning, and basic deployment	Proficient: Strong command of prompt engineering, data preprocessing, and query design	Advanced: Deep AI/ML expertise; experience with model training, orchestration, and enterprise integration
AI scenario examples	Use Microsoft Copilot Studio for simple tasks and workflows	Build AI apps such as chatbots for student academic support and for research	Deploy Generative AI and ML models for personalization and aid in decision-making	Scale with enterprise AI for predictive analytics and advanced research

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Assess AI skills

Acquire AI skills

Prioritize AI use cases

Create an AI Proof of Concept (POC)

Implement Responsible AI

Acquire AI skills

After assessing institutional expertise, universities should then take a structured, skills-focused approach to build an AI-ready workforce.

By determining whether to upskill, recruit, or partner for AI readiness. With AI evolving rapidly, continuous learning ensures faculty and staff stay ahead.



Develop AI skills with training & resources

Potential actions	Examples
Create dedicated learning time	Set aside time for faculty and staff to explore AI tools through hands-on experiments and sandbox environments, deepening understanding
Make learning engaging	Use gamified challenges, interactive exercises, and case studies to create a fun, low-pressure environment that supports skill development
Provide structured role-specific learning paths	Design training programs by skill level and role, starting with foundational AI concepts before advancing to specialized applications
Facilitate peer-to-peer learning	Host workshops, AI showcases, and collaboration sessions where employees share knowledge and strengthen AI fluency
Leverage existing AI training Resources	Use industry-recognized certifications and expert partnerships to expand faculty and staff expertise
Ensure continuous learning	Provide AI training to service partners to deliver continuous training
Promote responsible AI use	Integrate compliance training to ensure all AI users follow principles of fairness, transparency, and regulatory requirements



- Equip faculty, staff, and students with structured AI training by role and technology via the [AILearning Hub](#)
- Use the [Microsoft Learn Educator Center](#) for AI courses tailored to education, such as the AI for education [learning path](#)
- Earn [Microsoft Credentials for AI](#) certifications to gain applied skills in gen AI, machine learning, and analytics
- Engage with the [Microsoft Education AI Toolkit](#) to guide the AI journey

Prioritize AI use cases

Focus on institutional goals and impact

To maximize the impact of AI initiatives, institutions should engage stakeholders across departments to identify valuable use cases. A well-rounded approach ensures alignment with institutional priorities and broad-based support.

- **Assess Skills and Resources** – Evaluate AI maturity, data availability, and expertise to determine readiness and set priorities
- **Evaluate Use Cases** – Prioritize AI projects based on feasibility and strategic alignment to ensure meaningful contributions
- **Select Top Use Cases** – Identify high-impact AI applications for further testing and implementation

The following criteria offers an example of a potential structured approach to evaluating AI initiatives, whether through informal discussions or a formalized scorecard system:



Institutional Impact

Will this initiative deliver measurable, meaningful results aligned with institutional goals?



Feasibility

Does the institution have the necessary data, expertise, and funding to support success?



Time to implement

Is this a quick win to build momentum or a long-term investment with lasting benefits?



Ability to measure

Are the right tools and KPIs in place to accurately assess effectiveness?



Risk

What are the potential challenges, and what are the risks of not pursuing this initiative?

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Create an AI Proof of Concept (PoC)

Take the steps to create a successful AI Proof of Concept

Developing an AI proof of concept (PoC) tests the feasibility and value of a prioritized use case on a small scale. A structured PoC helps universities build a strong AI foundation while reducing risks.

By starting with internal initiatives and refining models iteratively, institutions can smoothly transition from experimentation to full-scale AI adoption.



Step 1: Select the right opportunity

Choose AI use cases that match your maturity level. Start with a low-risk internal project to build a foundation before scaling.

Step 2: Deploy rapidly with AI QuickStart Guides

Leverage Azure QuickStart Guides for step-by-step guidance on deploying AI applications.

Step 3: Reprioritize AI opportunities

Refine your AI use case list based on PoC insights. If challenges arise, shift focus to more feasible projects with higher impact



QuickStart Guides

- Generative AI: [Azure AI Foundry](#), [Azure OpenAI](#), [Copilot Studio](#)
- Machine Learning: [Azure Machine Learning](#)
- Analytical AI: [Azure AI Content Safety](#), [Azure AI Custom Vision](#), [Document Intelligence Studio](#), [Azure AI Language](#), [Azure AI Speech](#), [Azure AI Translator](#), [Azure AI Vision](#)

Check out the [Book of AI](#) for everything you need to know to get started with Azure AI services

Implement Responsible AI

Responsible AI should be embedded at every stage of AI planning and deployment. Universities must conduct impact assessments and establish governance policies that ensure fairness, transparency, and compliance. Responsible AI adoption should align AI initiatives with institutional values, protect user rights, and meet legal and regulatory standards.



Structured tools and frameworks that support responsible adoption:



[AI Impact Assessment Template](#)

Helps evaluate the potential social and economic effects of AI initiatives, ensuring proactive risk management



[Human-AI Experience Toolkit](#)

Guides the development of AI systems that prioritize user well-being and foster positive interactions between AI and humans



[Responsible AI Maturity Model](#)

Assists institutions in assessing their current responsible AI practices and advancing their AI governance framework



[Responsible AI for Workload Teams](#)

Provides recommendations for ensuring responsible AI implementation when building AI solutions in Azure environments

Conclusion: AI as a catalyst for higher education transformation

AI is about assisting the work of faculty, staff, and administrators.

When thoughtfully integrated, AI supports student engagement, empowers faculty, streamlines operations, and improves institutional efficiency.

For higher education leaders, the priority is ensuring AI adoption aligns with institutional mission and values. A strategic, responsible approach enables universities to leverage AI as a tool for innovation while maintaining trust, equity, and human oversight.

The time to act is now.

Universities that adopt AI today will help shape the future of education.

Is your institution ready for AI adoption? Start today by assessing AI readiness and identifying pilot projects that align with your university's strategic goals.



1: IDC InfoBrief: Sponsored by Microsoft, 2024 Business Opportunity of AI, IDC# US52699124, November 2024
[IDC's 2024 AI opportunity study: Top five AI trends to watch – The Official Microsoft Blog](#)

Data privacy statement:

Microsoft is committed to protecting customer data. Customer data is not used to train foundation models, and all AI solutions are built in alignment with Microsoft's privacy and compliance standards, including FERPA and GDPR. For more information, visit: <https://privacy.microsoft.com>